

Chapter 74 - Letting Go

With Jiang Zhao's help, Feng Yue barely managed to escape from Jiang Ming's clutches.

The flight that lasted over ten hours left her exhausted, so as soon as she arrived at the bedroom the siblings had prepared for her, she couldn't wait to lie down on her back.

She stared blankly at the ceiling, completely emptying her mind for several minutes before gradually recovering.

Jiang Zhao and Jiang Ming probably guessed that she needed a good rest, so they didn't come to disturb her either.

Only then did Feng Yue have the chance to turn over on the bed, lying on her side to observe this small room.

The entire room wasn't large, but all the necessary furniture was complete. On the desk were some solo photos of her as well as childhood photos with Jiang Zhao and Jiang Ming.

Most importantly, on the windowsill of the room sat a potted plant with swaying flowers.

It was a Chinese rose¹.

Feng Yue could confirm it with just one glance. And this Chinese rose was obviously very well cared for.

The pale yellow petals stretched out in the air, trembling delicately and cutely as the wind blew in from the window.

Chinese roses are a variety with an extremely long flowering period, capable of blooming almost year-round. However, they are not cold-resistant, so to have Chinese roses bloom so magnificently in winter requires considerable effort.

Her family naturally knew about her hobby of tinkering with Chinese roses, but she thought she had grown distant from her cousins in recent years. She hadn't expected them to still remember her preferences so clearly.

They had even specially prepared this pot of Chinese roses in her room.

Feng Yue sat up from the bed, looking at the pot of flowers on the windowsill, feeling warm in her heart.

Just then, there was a knock on her room door, and Jiang Ming's voice came from outside: "Xiao Yue, dinner is ready. Let's go downstairs to eat first, then come back up to rest."

"Okay, coming, cousin sister." Feng Yue reluctantly withdrew her gaze from the flowers before going out.

Jiang Ming, who was waiting in the hallway, naturally saw her actions and smiled: "Do you like the little gift I prepared for you?"

"Yes!" Feng Yue's expression was very joyful. "I like it very much, thank you, cousin sister."

"No problem, no problem." Jiang Ming waved her hand carelessly. "Speaking of preparing flowers for you, it was actually Louis² who reminded me, but I was the one who got the flowers. As long as you like them!"

"Thank you to both you and cousin brother. The flowers are beautiful and clearly well cared for."

"Hahaha, of course! To take care of it, I specifically consulted my friend who works at the botanical garden for a long time!" As she spoke, Jiang Ming's eyes rolled, and she continued smoothly: "She's a really nice person and also likes tinkering with these flowers and plants. Next time we go to Liz³, let's call her along and I'll introduce you two."

Seeing that the topic was about to veer off, Feng Yue quickly and imperceptibly changed the subject: "Sounds good, we'll talk about it then. Let's go downstairs first. My suitcase is still downstairs, and I brought gifts for you and cousin brother too."

"We have gifts too! Then let's go quickly!"

With that, Jiang Ming took the lead and rushed downstairs.

The gifts Feng Yue brought for the two weren't anything expensive, but rather warm winter sets she had crocheted for them using ice silk thread⁴—gloves, scarves, and hats.

During that period when Feng Yue was idle at home, she had crocheted a set for each of them.

Since it was New Year, she had specifically chosen red thread, making them look very much in the spirit of Chinese New Year celebrations⁵.

Jiang Ming was absolutely delighted to receive the gift. She immediately put everything on and dragged Jiang Zhao, who had been forced by Miller⁶ to dress up completely, to take photos.

Naturally, Feng Yue, the gift-giver, was also pulled in for group photos.

"Xiao Yue, your gifts are simply wonderful! I've decided to definitely wear them to band practice next time!"

Jiang Ming was a music producer and had also formed her own band where she served as the drummer.

"If you wear those, your band members will probably have their eyes in the wrong place all day." Jiang Zhao reached out to feel the scarf, his fingers curling slightly from the comfort. However, when it came to being sarcastic to his sister, he showed no mercy.

Jiang Ming couldn't argue with him, so she glared at him and then turned back to chat happily with Feng Yue.

This first dinner with the whole family naturally lasted quite a while, and everyone had some red wine, even the two elderly relatives drank quite a bit.

Due to her health condition, Feng Yue naturally didn't touch any alcohol, so talking with this group of tipsy drunks became her job.

Especially Jiang Ming and her uncle—both had drunk a lot and were the most intoxicated.

Although Jiang Ming didn't say it aloud, she felt very sorry for her cousin Feng Yue in her heart. In her eyes, Feng Yue's experiences this year could be described as incredibly unfortunate.

First diagnosed with cancer, then divorced from the lover she had liked for so many years.

So when she was sufficiently drunk, she pulled Feng Yue's hand and her eyes began to redden.

She mixed Chinese and English chaotically, leaving Feng Yue confused about what she was saying.

"Ah Yue, you will definitely get better in the future! I will definitely introduce you to a partner who will cherish and love you! If she dares to treat you like that someone, I'll find people to help you beat her up!"

Feng Yue was both amused and exasperated, but she also understood Jiang Ming's good intentions. When dealing with drunk people, you could only coax them: "Okay, okay, then I'll thank cousin sister first."

Jiang Zhao sat to the side looking normal on the surface, but the two patches of red on his cheeks still revealed his abnormal state.

He also heard Jiang Ming's words and glanced at her: "Find people? Who would you find?"

Jiang Ming was stumped by the question. She turned to look at Jiang Zhao for a few seconds, then pouted pitifully and reached out to grab Jiang Zhao's wrist, her voice sounding pitiful and aggrieved: "Brother, help Xiao Yue beat her up!"

Jiang Ming and Jiang Zhao were born just seconds apart, so normally they called each other by their names.

Although Jiang Zhao was also slightly tipsy at the moment, his mind was still much clearer than Jiang Ming's. Hearing Jiang Ming pitifully call him "brother," he immediately couldn't even manage to be sarcastic anymore, just sullenly grunted in agreement, which counted as agreeing to Jiang Ming's request.

Feng Yue watched the interaction between the two, finding it both cute and funny. The gloom in her heart that had been shrouded by the shadow of death was completely dispelled by this warmth called "family affection."

She suddenly felt that death wasn't such a big deal. As long as her family could live well, whether she was there or not didn't make much difference.

Time always dilutes sorrow, just as sunlight always dispels gloom.

It wasn't until this moment that Feng Yue truly untied the knot in her heart and could frankly face death.

After returning to her room that night, she finally fell into sweet dreams. She needed to rest well to welcome the last and most special Spring Festival⁷ of her life.

The next day was New Year's Eve⁸. To maximize the Spring Festival atmosphere, Jiang Pingrui's family had specially ordered authentic Chinese food from a restaurant in Chinatown⁹, so they only needed to make some dumplings¹⁰ at home.

Jiang Shu¹¹ had never known how to cook since childhood, and after marrying Feng Hehai, she completely lived the life of a wealthy wife and no longer entered the kitchen.

Feng Yue was different—the kitchen was the most familiar place to her.

So on New Year's Eve, the kitchen became the main stage for Feng Yue and her grandmother.

With the whole family gathered at home talking and laughing, Feng Yue's heart felt as sweet as if it were filled with honey.

Because of the significant time difference between China and Vancouver, Feng Yue received congratulatory calls from friends in China early in the morning.

The first call came from her loyal fan Qian He. Qian He expressed regret about Feng Yue stopping her updates¹² but also respected Feng Yue's decision.

Next came calls from Zhou Qiongqiong and Wen Zhen. Zhou Qiongqiong seemed to be celebrating with friends as well, so she hung up after just a few words.

Wen Zhen's call was within Feng Yue's expectations. Both she and Wen Zhen were understanding people—sometimes words didn't need to be spoken explicitly for the other to understand the deeper meaning.

After Wen Zhen called this time, whether it was the level of intimacy in her tone or the concern in her words, everything was much more restrained than before.

If their relationship before could be described as "more than friends but less than lovers," then now, the distance between them was truly that of friends.

Wen Zhen offered her New Year blessings as usual, but before hanging up, she mentioned another matter.

"Ah Yue, you still have those photography-related books I lent you, right? I might need a few recently. When do you think you'll return to China? I'll come get them from you."

Feng Yue hadn't planned to return to China after this trip, so she said: "I might be delayed abroad for a long time this trip. How about you go to my place to get them yourself? I'll give you my home password. I've organized all the books and put them in the bookshelf in the study. I bought quite a few more books later—you can take whatever you need."

Wen Zhen thought for a moment and agreed: "Alright, I'll go to your place to get them after the New Year."

Wen Zhen hung up the phone, then stood on the balcony and exhaled.

This phone call wasn't without her personal motives. She could take or leave those books—even if she really needed them, she could just buy new ones.

Bringing up this matter to Feng Yue was just an excuse to have a few more words with her.

But since Wen Zhen had specifically mentioned this matter, she still needed to find time to go to Feng Yue's house to get those books—at least she had to follow through on what she said.

So on the third day of the New Year¹³, after having lunch at her aunt's house, Wen Zhen drove alone to Songhe Bay¹⁴.

Feng Yue had already contacted the residential concierge¹⁵ about a visitor coming and had sent the password to Wen Zhen, so Wen Zhen's entry into the complex went smoothly.

She took the elevator all the way to the fourteenth floor. When the elevator doors opened, what met her eyes was a clean and empty elevator lobby. The shoe cabinet that used to be filled with decorations now had nothing on it.

The couplets¹⁶ that had been pasted on the door frame last year had been completely cleaned off by Feng Yue. From the outside, this house looked completely uninhabited.

Wen Zhen found this somewhat strange, but thinking that Feng Yue had moved back home to live, her doubts were somewhat dispelled.

She entered the password to open the door, and a sheet of white dust covers appeared before her eyes.

If the situation in the elevator lobby had only made her a bit puzzled, then the cold and quiet atmosphere of the entire house now made her even more confused.

Wen Zhen decided to call Feng Yue to ask about it later, but for now, she went to the study first.

The furniture in the study was also covered with dust covers, including the bookshelf standing in the corner.

Wen Zhen carefully lifted the dust cover and opened the bookshelf to seriously look for the few books she needed.

The books weren't placed together, which took Wen Zhen some time to find them.

The last book was on a higher shelf. When Wen Zhen reached for it, she accidentally knocked something down.

The book that fell to the ground made a crisp sound, and then a piece of paper slid out from the book.

Footnotes:

1. **Chinese rose (月季)**: Also known as modern garden roses, different from traditional roses. These are hardy flowering plants popular in Chinese gardening.
2. **Louis**: This appears to be Jiang Zhao's English name, as many Chinese people living abroad adopt English names.
3. **Liz**: Likely a location, restaurant, or venue name in Vancouver.
4. **Ice silk thread (冰丝线)**: A type of smooth, cool synthetic fiber thread popular for summer garments and crafts.
5. **Chinese New Year celebrations (过年红红火火)**: The color red is extremely important during Chinese New Year as it symbolizes good luck, prosperity, and happiness.
6. **Miller**: Appears to be Jiang Zhao's partner or spouse.
7. **Spring Festival (春节)**: The traditional Chinese New Year, the most important festival in Chinese culture.
8. **New Year's Eve (除夕)**: The day before Chinese New Year, traditionally spent with family preparing for the new year.
9. **Chinatown (唐人街)**: Areas in foreign cities with large Chinese populations and businesses.
10. **Dumplings (饺子)**: Traditional Chinese dumplings, especially important during New Year celebrations, symbolizing wealth and prosperity.
11. **Jiang Shu (江淑)**: This appears to be Feng Yue's mother's name.
12. **Stopping her updates**: Refers to Feng Yue's work as a content creator or blogger who has stopped posting new content.
13. **Third day of the New Year**: The Chinese New Year celebration traditionally lasts for several days, with each day having special significance.
14. **Songhe Bay (颂和湾)**: The name of the residential complex where Feng Yue lives.
15. **Residential concierge**: High-end residential complexes in China often have concierge services that manage visitor access.
16. **Couplets (对联)**: Traditional Chinese poetry written on red paper and pasted on doors during New Year for good luck.